

Sentinels of the Dawn

Poor Clares of Perpetual Adoration
Our Lady of the Angels Monastery
Troyes, France

Winter 2016 Issue 18

A Spiritual Journey with Mary and Joseph



Each year, Advent offers us the opportunity of taking a journey whose itinerary is quite different from the « winter holiday » frenzy that surround us. Advent calls us to be still, to listen, and to follow a path marked out by the holy men and women of old. Like a star shining it the night, it bears within it the hope of eternal life, a hope that no money can buy and no darkness can overcome.

Let us walk with Mary, who never expected to be chosen as the Mother of the Messiah, and with her husband Joseph who discovered in a dream that Mary had conceived a son by the Holy Spirit whom he was to name Jesus (Matthew 1, 19-25).

The 70 mile journey from Galilee to Bethlehem was dangerous, exhausting, and uncomfortable especially for a woman in the eighth month of her pregnancy. There were no restaurants or hotels along the way and one could only bring the essential things. We can follow their example by removing from our lives anything that will weigh us down on our journey to see the Christ Child. We can de-clutter our lives by collecting less and giving more. We can clean the inner room of our hearts by taking time to pray, to visit someone who is sick or lonely, and by receiving the Sacrament of Reconciliation, so that when we stand before the manger to greet the Newborn King, He will delight in our hearts open to receive Him.

We were blessed to have our Bishop, the Most Reverend Marc Stenger, come to our Monastery on September 12th for what is called a "canonical visit". All religious communities have such visits regularly so that their members can be strengthened to follow Christ faithfully, generously, courageously. During our visit, each Sister had the privilege to speak one on one with him, expressing their concerns, needs and desires for the future of our Community. We were very grateful for our Bishop's attentiveness and support, as well as his encouraging words and suggestions.



On September 16th, our Bishop also presided at our Chapter of Elections, which concluded on October 24th. Mother Mary Emmanuel was re-elected Abbess; Sister Mary Rosalia was elected Vicar and Sister Mary Antoinette 2nd Councilor.

We recommend to your prayers our Sisters who were chosen to help build up the life of our Community through their roles of service. May the Holy Spirit guide them in their work and inspire them in their decisions. May our Community continue to walk together along the path that the Lord has opened for us, as we strive to live together in sisterly love and unity, and draw others to Jesus through our life dedicated to Perpetual Adoration.

We pray that the Nativity of our Lord Jesus Christ
fill your hearts with joy and peace.
May the Prince of Peace bless you and your loved ones
during this holy season and throughout 2017.

Merry Christmas from your
Poor Clare Nuns of Perpetual Adoration in Troyes, France



The memory of our deceased loved ones lives on...

During the month of November, we pray in a special way for all the deceased among our Communities, our family and friends as well as the benefactors of our Monastery. In 2016, several loved ones dear to the hearts of our Sisters were called home to their Eternal reward. We would like to pay special hommage to three great women of faith who have left their mark in our lives.

For many years, Mother Mary Joseph was the Abbess of our Monastery in Kollam, India, as well as President of the Association of all our Monasteries in India. She worked tirelessly to strengthen the life of each Community and the vocation of each Sister as an Adorer of the Most Blessed Sacrament. She was in many ways a « pioneer », courageous and undaunted in doing what she believed God was asking. She was very supportive of the re-opening of our Troyes Monastery and sent us two of her best : Sister Mary Rosalia and Sister Mary Germaine ; in 2013 she also honored us with a visit. Her beautiful smile, lively intelligence, wisdom and teaching will be remembered forever by her Sisters. On February 12, 2016 God called her to share in His Eternal Life.



Another Poor Clare of Perpetual Adoration, Mother Mary Angelica, is well known thanks to the EWTN Catholic television network which she founded. Mother Angelica never did anything half-heartedly for God. She was willing to be called foolish , to take enormous risks, to move ahead despite much opposition in order to do what she believed God was asking of her. Who would ever have imagined, except God, that a cloistered nun whose community made fishing tackles to support her Catholic television station housed in their garage would gradually evolve into the N°1 Christian TV network in the entire world ? Despite this grand endeavor, Mother never lost sight of her first calling - to be a Spouse of Christ and an Adorer of the Blessed Sacrament. Her time of prayer before the Holy Eucharist was the source of her life and without Christ, she could do nothing. In 2002, Mother Angelica suffered a stroke. One of the greatest evangelists of our time was silenced and confined to a bed where she shared in the suffering Jesus ; it was perhaps her greatest work. On Easter Sunday 2016, Mother closed her eyes to this world and was welcomed into the arms of the Father's merciful love. We shall be forever grateful to her for the support that she and her community have continually given to our Troyes Monastery, especially in sending us two wonderful Sisters : Sr. Mary Antoinette and Sr. Faustina Marie.



A native of Aube, Mrs. Edith Bégé, has been a long-time friend of our Monastery. Her deep faith and love for her family were a blessing for her children and grand-children. Her devotion to the founder of our Order, Father Bonaventure Herlaut, was lovingly expressed with bouquets of flowers placed on his tomb in the cemetery of the church in Nogent-sur-Aube where he was Curé and where she lived for many years. In the 1960's, her daughter, Mrs. Agnès Branche, and her husband purchased the rectory of the church where Father Bonaveture died and transformed it into a magnificent restaurant, L'Assiette de Vallée de l'Aube, now operated by her family. On August 25th, 2016, Mme Bégé passed from this life into Eternity. Her quiet, simple nature deeply touched our hearts and we have no doubt that she is interceding for us from above...along with Father Bonaventure !



During the Jubilee Year of Mercy we had been praying about where we could create a sacred space, such as a prayer corner or a little altar marked with the theme of Jesus' mercy. It was our desire as well that it would remain even after the closing of the jubilee year. The Holy Spirit inspired us with the idea of using our Mother Foundress' former cell (monastic term for bedroom). It has remained vacant over the years, but her presence is very much felt. Thanks to a friend of the Monastery who volunteered his time and talent, the room was repainted and was transformed into a little oratory for the Sisters. Because our Foundress had a great devotion to the Holy Face of Jesus, we gave the Oratory this title. What more beautiful image of mercy than the face of Christ gazing back at us. Along with a beautiful framed photo of the Holy Face of Jesus, offered to us by a benefactor, we also hung photos of our founders. We feel our Foundress' presence even more so now and implore her maternal protection over her daughters who desire to continue the mission that she once began over 150 years ago. Please join us in praying that she may send us good, holy French vocations.



A Trio of Musicians making music for the Lord

Amidst our little Community of Sisters, we are blessed to have a handful of musicians who use their talents to add beauty to the liturgy and thus give glory to God. Each day we have the privilege of participating in the sacrifice of the Holy Mass and of chanting the entire Liturgy of the Hours in the name of the Church. Our voices are blended with the sounds of strings and pipes coming from hands of our Sister musicians !

Most of you are already familiar with our Sister Mary Antoinette, a former professional violinist, whose music sends her listeners to the 7th heaven ! Although Sister's days of playing in the symphony are over, she never seems to lose her special touch as she plays with her whole being during Mass on Sundays and solemn feasts, as well as other special occasions. As you know, she has already recorded two CD's at the Cathedral of Saints Peter and Paul in Troyes with the titualur organist, Mr. Michael Matthes. They are still available to purchase through our website : www.clarissesdetroyes.com. A third one will be produced in the spring of 2017. The proceeds from their sale go towards helping us with the renovation projects of our Monastery. We will keep you posted on further details.



Another musician in our midst, is Mother Marie Emmanuel. Despite her many activities and responsibilities are Abbess of our Community, Mother Mary Emmanuel always makes time for something that is so dear to her – the Liturgy. Two or three times a week, the Community gathers for music practice and Mother introduces the Sisters to music which will be incorporated into the Liturgy.



Last but not least, Sister Mary Raphael is our debutant cithariste. Her goal is to accompany the Sisters during the chanting of the psalms in the Divine Office. We are grateful to our Brother Olivétains in Mesnil St Loup, who donated a cithare to us, as well as a community of Poor Clare Sisters in France, who gave us a generous cithare-starter donation. Thanks to this divine providence, Sister Mary Raphael was able to attend a week-long session at the Benedictine Abbey of St Thierry. We can expect great things from her in the future, thanks to her desire and perseverance.



May Saint Cecilia, patron of musicians, intercede for our Sisters in all their loving endeavors to add beauty to our liturgical services through their music.



For our annual Community retreat during this Jubilee Year of Mercy we had the great joy of receiving Fr. Barry Braum and Fr. Gary Holmes. Both priests belong to the Community of the Missionaries of the Holy Eucharist. Founded in 2007 in southern France, their mission is to promote perpetual adoration in parishes, here in France, as well as other countries where they are asked to visit.

During our four day retreat, Fr Gary preached on the Word of God at Mass, while Fr Barry gave us two conferences each day. Both of them focused on drawing near to Jesus in the Holy Eucharist through discovering the Word Himself in the Holy Scriptures. We give thanks to God for these holy priests and for the many graces and blessings we received during this time of prayer and silence. May we continue to grow in our knowledge and love of Jesus and enter more fully into a personal relationship with Him who is the Way, the Truth and the Life.



It was in October of 2013 that we first met Mother Marilla, a Benedictine of the Sacred Heart, along with another Sister who came to pay us a visit. At that time they were just beginning a new foundation in St Loup-sur-Aujon. Like our Order, their charism is Perpetual Adoration. Since then we have kept in contact and formed a spiritual bond with them before the Most Blessed Sacrament. This past September, we received news that Mother Marilla had been elected Mother General of their Congregation. The day she left to return to the Motherhouse in London, she stopped to visit with us one more time with the former Mother General, Mother Xavier. Although the afternoon passed all too quickly, we were happy to share a meal together and each others good company (with lots of laughs, too!) We recommend dear Mother Marilla and her new mission to your prayers, that the Lord may bless her abundantly.



Our annual Christmas sale was held on November 30th and Decemebr 1st. This year our Sisters provided items to be sold - bio apple juice, quince jellies and homemade loaf pan cakes. For some of them we used vegetables and fruits from their garden. In the evening there was also a stand selling oysters, with an area where customers could sit and eat outside. Many braved the cold weather to attend the event. We are grateful to three couples, good friends of our Monastery, whose hard work, creativity, and enthuiasm made the sale a great success. The benefits will be used to help pay for the renovation work of our Monastery.





After a long period of waiting, we are happy to announce that phase four of the renovation projects of our Monastery will begin in mid-december 2016. As we mentioned in our last newsletter, the work will include the renovation of nine cells on the second floor of the Monastery ; on the first floor, the long-awaited, modest library and the archives. We turn to St Joseph, asking him to watch over this project, protect the workers from all harm and bless those who have come to our aide financially and spiritually. May God reward you !

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Our newest arrival



Hi ! My name is Symba and I am a miniature Labrador. I am a little less than a year and a half old. Back in September, I was residing at the local animal shelter for a short time. One day, two women who were wearing long brown robes and cords around their waist, with black veils on their heads arrived at the animal shelter. Passing from cage to cage, they looked at my dog friends, some big and some small. Finally, they came to mine. I tried to make a good impression with them, by standing tall and firm, wagging my tail with enthusiasm and looking at them with my big brown eyes. I was hoping against hope that I would be the one they were looking for. But, unfortuantely, they left without me or any other dog. A few days later, the two brown-robed ladies return to the shelter and to my great delight, the lock on my cage was opened ! Before I knew it, I was placed in a car and was going home with them. I was happy, to say the least, to be living once again in a real home, amidst loving, caring people. Since I am young and have a lot of energy, I like to run around the yard and play ball with the Sisters. Sometimes when I'm bored, I dig holes in the flower garden. I've seen the Sisters do this, too (with their hands and tools) but when they saw what I had done, they didn't seem to happy about my brilliant idea ! Looks like I will need to break that bad habit soon. Stay posted for more adventures from « Super Symba » in future newsletters....